

CRICKETS AND GRASSHOPPERS

Orthoptera are mainly herbivorous. They have two pairs of wings, although some can be short-winged or wingless. The hind legs are often large and used for jumping. They sing by rubbing their front wings together or their hind legs on a wing edge.

COMMON FIELD GRASSHOPPER

Chorthippus brunneus

F: Acrididae

This grasshopper is typically found on short, dry, grazed grassland in Europe, N. Africa, and temperate Asia, where it is most active on sunny days.

WELLINGTON TREE WETA

Hemideina crassidens

F: Anostomatidae

Native to New Zealand, this nocturnal insect lives in rotten wood and tree stumps. It eats plant material as well as small insects.

AFRICAN CAVE CRICKET

Phaeophilacris bredoides

F: Rhaphidophoridae

This C. African species is an omnivorous scavenger. It has very long antennae, an adaptation to life in dark micro-habitats.

DESERT LOCUST

Schistocerca gregaria

F: Acrididae

Crowding of nymphs after rain stimulates this African insect to transform from a solitary into a gregarious form. It swarms in billions, devastating crops.

OAK BUSH CRICKET

Meconema thalassinum

F: Tettigoniidae

Found on a range of broadleaved trees, this European cricket feeds on small insects after dark. The female has a long, curved ovipositor.

ovipositor for laying eggs

LEAF-ROLLING CRICKET

Hyalogryllacris subdebilis

F: Gryllacrididae

Found in Australia, this species has relatively long wings and very long antennae, which may be up to three times the length of the body.

MOLE CRICKET

Gryllotalpa gryllotalpa

F: Gryllotalpidae

This species from Europe uses its strong front legs to burrow, just like a miniature mole. It is found in meadows and banks near rivers, where the soil is damp and sandy.

HOUSE CRICKET

Acheta domestica

F: Gryllidae

A nocturnal species, the house cricket makes an attractive chirping song. Originally from S.W. Asia and N. Africa it has spread into Europe.

SOUTHERN FIELD CRICKET

Gryllus bimaculatus

F: Gryllidae

This cricket is widespread in S. Europe, parts of Africa, and Asia and lives on the ground under wood or debris.

FOAMING GRASSHOPPER

Dictyophorus spumans

F: Pyrgomorphidae

Bright colours advertise that this South African grasshopper is toxic to predators. It can also produce a noxious foam from its thoracic glands.

COCKROACHES

Members of the order Blattodea are scavenging insects, with a flattened oval body. The downward-pointing head is often largely concealed by a shield-like pronotum and there are usually two pairs of wings. The tip of the abdomen has a pair of sensory organs, or cerci.

MADAGASCAN HISSING COCKROACH

Gromphadorhina portentosa

F: Blaberidae

This large, wingless cockroach is reared worldwide as a pet. The male has prominent bumps on the thorax for male-to-male combat.

DUSKY COCKROACH

Ectobius lapponicus

F: Ectobiidae

Small and fast running, this European species can be found among leaf litter and occasionally in foliage. It has been introduced into the USA.

AMERICAN COCKROACH

Periplaneta americana

F: Blattidae

This species, which was originally from Africa, is now found worldwide. It lives on ships and in food warehouses.

TERMITES

These nest-building social insects of the order Isoptera live in colonies with different castes: reproductives (the kings and queens), workers, and soldiers. Workers are generally pale and wingless; reproductives have wings that are shed after a nuptial flight; and soldiers have a large head and jaws.

SUBTERRANEAN TERMITE

Coptotermes formosanus

F: Rhinotermitidae

Native to S. China, Taiwan, and Japan, this invasive species has now spread to other parts of the world, where it is a serious pest.

PACIFIC DAMPWOOD TERMITE

Zootermopsis angusticollis

F: Archotermitidae

This termite, found along the Pacific coastal states of N. America, nests in and feeds on decayed, fungus-infected wood.